Daddy's Little Girl

by Jason Sheets

DADDY: **(Pgs 153-157)** When my daughter came home from school with bruises on her arms and back, I scheduled an appointment with the principal the next day. The principal reassured me:

PRINCIPAL: I can't imagine Katie is having any problems with bullies. She seems to be adjusting to junior high very well.

DADDY: After telling him to keep an eye out, the bruises got darker but the principal reported nothing. I took Katie to the doctor so we could document the bruises . . .

DOCTOR: Sir, I've taken the liberty to run some tests. The bruises are not the result of bullying. Your daughter has leukemia. Do you think we should tell her together?

DADDY: No . . . I'll tell her. *(to audience)* Katie and I had always done everything one-on-one. Daddy's little girl was about to embark on the fight of her life.

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INTRODUCTION

Katie's favorite song is . . .
**(sings)* *Blue skies smilin' at me.*
Nothin' but blue skies do I see.
Bluebirds singin' a song.
Nothin' but bluebirds all day long. . .

Blue days, all of them gone.
Nothin' but blue skies from now on.
Blue skies smilin' at me
Nothin' but blue skies do I see . . .

And we did. We tried to see the blue skies every single day from that moment on.

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DADDY: I hate diseases that you don't know how serious they are so you have to anticipate both the worst and best case scenarios. Like our neighbor -- diagnosed with Parkinson's disease. You have to say" Oh, I'm so sorry" and then go ask people if there is a cure. My aunt has diabetes. People think she's dying, but she lives a healthy life. We just aren't very informed on what constitutes three strikes.

Leukemia? For leukemia the answer is "kind of" and when you ask if it's three strikes, they make this face that suggests "we'll treat her and find out."

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Katie is a daddy's girl by default. Her mother, as much as I love her, spends weeks at a time on assignment as a news reporter. That makes me not only father, but food supervisor, activities director, and special assignment counselor all at once. With only one child, I had the time and was more than willing to do it. Mothers bond during pregnancy; father's bond by choice. Now, sometimes it got awkward. She's a girl, after all. Suddenly, I'm thrown into bake sales:

KATIE: Daddy, can we make something besides Rice Krispie treats?

DADDY: Katie, no, we can't. Trust me, daddy is not possibly capable of more than this. Where's the marshmallow? *(to audience)* And I'm critiquing ballet recitals: *(to Katie)* Dear, you were the best. The way you. . . jumped around and all. On your toes! *(to audience)* Last summer, it was shopping for a training bra. *(to Katie)* This one looks like it'll provide some support.

KATIE: Dad!

DADDY: How about this colorful one over here?

KATIE: Dad!

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DADDY: No matter how much I wasn't capable of handling the job, the job of loving her was my pride and joy. She says I'll be the best man at her wedding. *(to Katie)* Don't you think your groom should have that choice?

KATIE: Not if he wants to marry me!

DADDY: We talk about everything. Even the leukemia. Treatments come, treatments go. We talk about every moment. At least I think so. She may have moments she keeps for herself. If she does, I'm OK with that.

In the morning, I wake her for school and I hurriedly brush away all the excess hair she has lost during the night. She knows it's gone, but seeing it makes it more real, more final. The summer before she enters 9th grade, we find ourselves not shopping for a training bra, but instead shopping for a wig. God, what I would give for bra shopping right now! Donning her Notre Dame baseball cap, I realize that she fits her nickname. The Fighting Irish. Her mom was born in Dublin. Now, she was fighting. She fights; I grasp for control. I also pay for the wig. It doesn't look great. They make these things for adults.

KATIE: Dad, what do you think?

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DADDY: *(to audience)* She asks as if she's playing dress-up, sorting through all of her possible outfits. *(to Katie)* You look beautiful, Katie. *(to audience)* She did. I wasn't lying. Even with the tawdry wig, Katie shined.

Treatments come, treatments go. Where they stop, nobody knows. Is it wrong that I'm joking? Rhyming? I mean, c'mon, I don't even know what to pray for. Do I want the treatments to continue? No. But do I want them to stop? Stopping could mean remission. It could also mean three strikes. So, I pray for neither, simply discussing them with Katie and dismissing them when she starts to cry. When Katie tells me she wants to go to the school dance, I hesitate as only a father can do.

KATIE: C'mon, dad! I even got a date. Keith Roush. He's dreamy looking. You'd like him.

DADDY: Trust me, if a pre-pubescent teen has targeted my daughter for his hormonal attacks, I don't like him. But, I have to admire his good taste. *(to Katie)* Can I chaperone?

KATIE: Sure, dad, it'll be fun. Keith wanted to know if you could drive us there anyway.

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DADDY: *(to audience)* Prepping for the dance, I realize her mother should be here for this. I'm doing my best with the perfume and make-up. When it doesn't look great, I say: Why don't we go for the natural look?

Before we leave, I give her my lecture: *(to Katie)* Just remember, even though you're old enough to go out on a date, you'll always be *(sings)* ****Daddy's Little Girl***.

KATIE: Man, dad, you aren't going to sing that song again, are you? It's depressing. Makes me feel like I'm leaving you and we can't hang out anymore. Can you try something cheerier? What about the *Blue Sky* song?

DADDY: *(to Katie)* How about we go pick up Keith. He must be waiting. *(to audience)* At the dance, they do what is called "The Grand March." All of the couples get together, line up, and walk down the staircase to the dance floor. Patiently waiting as dozens of couples go by, I'm prepared to be proud of my Katie.

LOUDSPEAKER (Voice Over): Next, Katie Merrit and Keith Roush.

DADDY: Suddenly, I see her shoes hit the first step. Slowly, step by step, she comes into focus. The dress looks great and *(shocked pause)* And she's not wearing her wig.

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Beaming like a choirgirl, my bald little girl comes down the stairs. She walks to me and says . . .

KATIE: I want them to like me for who I am. I've got no hair, no boobs, and no curves. So be it!

DADDY: Honey, you're beautiful.

KATIE: I feel it!

DADDY: *(to audience)* Keith asks her if she wants to dance. Good boy.

Treatments come, treatments go. Then she gets sicker. Hospital stays come and go. Mom tries to stay home more. The only thing that doesn't come and go is Katie and I. Playing Rack-O on the hospital bed, I wonder how many more moments I will get. The unscientific answer: too few. *(beat)*

I greet Katie bright and early at 6:30. *(to Katie, entering the hospital room with a tray)* Rise and shine! What would you like today? Strained carrots or strained . . . Katie? Katie? *(to audience)* The nurse informs me:

NURSE: *(softly)* She's slipped into a coma.

DADDY: Katie? Katie? *(to Nurse)* Damn it, no! Damn it, no one is taking Katie!

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NURSE: Sir, I'm sorry, but you knew this would happen soon. . .

DADDY: But it's not supposed to work out this way. I ask the doctor: *(to Doctor)* Will she live?

DOCTOR: We'll see.

DADDY: *(panicked, to audience)* That's not a no. That's a "We'll see." That is a "We will see!!" *(to Katie)* Wake up. Wake up, Katie, your father is talking to you! You're in big trouble if you don't wake up right now! *(praying)* Oh, God. Please, God. We're in big trouble if she doesn't wake up right now. *(long beat)*

(to audience) Six hours later, Katie passed away. Three weeks shy of sweet sixteen. I don't know what to do. Reinvent speaking with my wife?

On her birthday, I enter her bedroom for the first time. Her first place 4- H ribbon. The picture of her with Pluto at Disney World. Her wig. I spot a journal I have never seen before. In it, a note is addressed to me:

KATIE: *(voice over) Dear Dad, If you are reading this and I'm still alive, put down the journal right now, you nosy butt! If you are reading this after I'm gone, read on.*

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I love you, dad. I'll miss my dad a ton, but I'll miss my best friend more. That's you, too, by the way! You've looked after me all these years, now I'll look after you from above. Sing to me every once and a while. I always like that.

DADDY: *(tear-filled pause)* Um, she always wanted that song that was cheerier what was it? Blue Sky? Oh yes, Blue Sky. *(sings)* Blue skies smilin' at me. / Nothin' but blue skies . . . *(as he continues reading, he interrupts his tune)* Oh, wait . . .

KATIE: *PS: If you want to sing" Daddy's Little Girl" now, it's OK. It doesn't depress me anymore.*

DADDY: This one's for you, honey:

(sings)
***You're the end of the rainbow; You're my shining star,*
You're sugar and spice;
You're everything nice and you're Daddy's little girl.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jason Sheets
Book: Turning Points, Pgs 153-157
Publisher: Tichenor Publishing
ISBN: 978-0742117013
Date: 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

Blue Skies written by Irving Berlin and sung by Ella Fitzgerald – available here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SAa4teWb0rU

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Daddy's Little Girl written by Robert Harrison Burke and Horace Gerlach in 1949 and sung by Al Martino – available here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hS1agWrWkS4